

3. With molecular manufacturing, international trade in both raw materials and finished goods will get replaced by decentralized production for local consumption, using locally available materials. The absence of international trade will lead to the death of common interest
4. With almost two hundred sovereign nations, each struggling to create a new economic and social order, perhaps the most predictable outcome is chaos: shifting alignments, displaced populations, power struggles, and conflicts inflamed by demagogues, etc.
5. If nuclear weapons remain limited in number, advanced nanotechnology could facilitate extensive civil defense construction, and provide active defense and counterforce weapons, undermining the nuclear “balance of terror” and creating the appearance of a possibility of victory in a war between major powers.
6. Advanced nanotechnology should also facilitate a possible nuclear rearmament to levels manifold higher than those of any other War the world has seen. Thus it is possible that the result of a nanotechnic arms race will be rampant nuclear proliferation and the expansion of major nuclear arsenals to warhead counts in the hundred thousands or millions
7. In the event of a showdown, an imbalance in deployed hardware could allow one side to strike the weaker one with impunity and ensure victory. If military production is based on a self-replicating capital base with a short generation time, unprecedentedly large masses of military hardware could be produced in an unprecedentedly short time.
8. Even if two sides are evenly matched, high levels of deployed armaments may be militarily unstable, in that a surprise attack could perhaps decimate the opposing force before it could even respond.

The nanotechnic era will be fundamentally different from the era in which nuclear weapons were developed and came to dominate the possibilities for global violence. We have managed to avoid a nuclear war only because the



Can we fight it?

bombed-out cities of the Second World War, and the nuclear holocausts of our imagination, have persuaded rational minds that there can be no expectation of a meaningful victory in total war between states armed with hundreds of deliverable nuclear weapons.